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Focus Groups and Social Interaction

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The primary topic of this chapter is a practical approach to interaction in focus groups. This approach is practical in two ways. First, it examines how the process of interaction is related to the *substantive information* that the group participants generate. Second, it describes how a project's *research design* can affect the nature of the interaction in the participants. My methodological orientation derives from the version of pragmatism associated with John Dewey and George Herbert Mead, while my general orientation to the understanding of interaction in focus groups comes from symbolic interaction — which also originated from Mead's work.

Based on the symbolic interactionist tradition (Mead, 1934), I treat interaction as based on shared meanings that are created and negotiated by the participants in the course of their interaction. Following the classic framework of interactionism, all the participants in a focus group simultaneously conceive of both their own role and the roles that others play. This close connection between identity and interaction can be traced back to Cooley's (1909) concept of the “looking-glass self,” where individuals find the meanings of their own actions in the reactions of others. It is also important to recognize that Mead (1934) considered most aspects of thought to be a form of interaction that occurs within “the little theater of the mind.” In addition, Mead treated interaction as inseparable from the broader social context that extended beyond the boundaries of face-to-face contact, to include the host of other identities that participants possess. Thus, the interaction that occurs in focus groups involves all the elements of *Mind, Self, and Society* (Mead, 1934).

The pragmatic orientation in this chapter is devoted to the connections between research design and group interaction. Although it is up to the participants themselves to initiate and sustain their own discussion, the decisions that we make as researchers can have a major influence on the nature of that discussion. As a philosophy, pragmatism has a central emphasis on action and experience (e.g., Dewey, 1933), with a process of deliberation and decision making standing between past experience and future action. Making decisions about research design is a process of anticipating what difference it would make to conduct focus groups in one way rather than another, and this deliberation on our possible actions and their likely outcomes is at the core of pragmatism. From a research point of view, we need to decide on research designs that are likely to create the desired forms of interaction within our focus groups. Specifically, as we think about decisions that can affect the nature of interaction in focus groups, we need to consider the differences that arise from choices such as setting up the group composition, writing the interview questions, and selecting the style of moderating.

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Taken together, this joint emphasis on symbolic interactionism and pragmatism converges on the topic of shared meanings. On the one hand, my interactionist outlook shapes my thoughts about how participants create shared meanings through their interactions. On the other hand, my pragmatic orientation shapes my thoughts about how my own actions, as a researcher, also have an impact on the participants' interactions, and thus on the meanings that they share in their conversations. It needs to be clear, however, that creating “shared meanings” is not the same as having participants agree with each other, and this chapter will pay attention to a variety of forms of interaction. Ultimately, what matters most is not the form a focus group takes but what the participants actually say to each other and to us.

This chapter is divided into three basic sections. The first section lays out the current approach to interaction in focus groups, which concentrates on the “co-construction of meaning.” This approach falls between the two most common approaches to designing and analyzing focus groups, which emphasize either the meaning of the content in the discussion or the conversational dynamics that occur within that discussion. The second section proposes a process of “sharing and comparing” as a basic element in participants' co-construction of meaning in focus groups. The participants use this process to share similar ideas and compare different ideas with regard to the research topic, and this interaction helps them develop a shared perspective on that topic. The third major section proposes “organizing and conceptualizing” as a higher-level process in the co-construction of meaning. Once the early interaction in the groups gives participants a shared sense of the various aspects of the topic, this creates the opportunity for the participants to organize these basic elements into a more abstract set of concepts, which helps them express why they feel the way they do about the topic.

Each of the two sections on the co-construction of meaning will include practical advice on how to design focus groups that will promote sharing and comparing as well as organizing and conceptualizing. On the one hand, there is more information about the process of sharing and comparing. The advice in that section will be on specific techniques for designing focus groups that generate sharing and comparing as a desired form of interaction. On the other hand, there is less specific information about how to achieve organizing and conceptualizing in focus groups; the advice in that section will concentrate on techniques that can produce a better understanding of this more abstract process. Overall, the emphasis on the co-construction of meaning matches the chapter's symbolic interactionist orientation, while the emphasis on design decisions that encourage the coconstruction of meaning matches the chapter's pragmatic orientation.

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Studying Interaction in Focus Groups

Content-Oriented and Conversation-Oriented Research

Although focus groups are indeed a form of interviewing, the source of the data is the interaction among the participants in these interviews. Surprisingly, the study of interaction continues to receive relatively little attention, although a number of articles have criticized this lack of attention (e.g., Kitzinger, 1994; Wilkinson, 1998b). Duggleby (2005) provides a useful review of two of the most common targets for this critique: (1) the analysis of data from focus groups and (2) the reporting of the results from that analysis. It is impossible to deny the importance of interaction in focus groups, but even so, I have argued (Morgan, 2010) that this does imply that interaction is the central concern for every project that uses focus groups. In particular,

> saying that the interaction in focus groups produces the data is not the same as saying that the interaction itself is the data. … [C]hoices about the analysis and reporting of interaction in focus groups must be made within the context of the needs and goals of the overall project.
>
> (p. 718)

Along with making a strong argument for paying more attention to interaction in focus groups, Duggleby (2005) also agrees with the fundamental pragmatist point that the goal of the research must determine the use of the methods (see Macnaghten & Myers, 2004, for a similar argument).

In describing the different goals that focus groups can serve, I have distinguished between purposes that are oriented to substantive content and those that relate to the conversational dynamics (Morgan, 2010). Content-oriented studies are by far the most common of the two, largely because they include almost all the work devoted to applied goals and practical uses for focus groups. For this purpose, the microdynamics of the conversation are largely irrelevant. In contrast, the less common studies that use either conversation analysis (Schegloff, 2007) or discourse analysis (Puchta & Potter, 2004) represent the most explicit attention to the actual conversations in focus groups. In this case, the conversations in focus group discussions are almost always used as a convenient site for studying interaction in general, so the specific subject of the discussion is largely irrelevant.

The difference between content-oriented and conversation-oriented research is exemplified by the long-term

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coauthorship team of Phil Macnaghten and Greg Myers, who have used their mutual experience to compare these two approaches (Macnaghten & Myers, 2004). Thus, content-oriented researchers such as Macnaghten typically use a more directive style of moderating to elicit useful content on their topic of interest, while conversation-oriented researchers such as Myers typically use a less structured style that lets them hear how the participants set their own agenda. For analysis, the difference is between using a well-defined goal to locate the most important themes in the discussion and searching for patterns in the way participants talk to each other and to the moderator. For interpretation of data, the difference is between finding statements that are relevant to the final report of the data and treating focus groups as a particular example of conversation that makes it possible to hear ongoing interaction. For reporting the research, content-oriented researchers apply their results to debates and decisions related to a specific topic, while conversation-oriented researchers contribute to the academic debate within their field of interest.

Macnaghten and Myers (2004, p. 74) provide a useful summary of these distinctions by comparing the approaches to focus groups. Whereas Phil Macnaghten represents researchers who are interested in the substantive content of focus groups and concentrate on *"what* was said," Greg Myers represents researchers in conversation analysis, who concentrate on *"how* it was said." By coincidence, I used the same language (Morgan, 2010) to argue for "the inherent connection between the substantive content of 'what' participants say and the interactive dynamics of 'how' participants say those things" (p. 718). Acknowledging this connection between the content of interaction and the processes that produce that content only takes us so far, however. The real problem is getting back and forth between these two forms of analysis. In my opinion, the most reasonable way to bridge this gap is by introducing a middle level, where the substance of the current conversation is linked to both the content of the ongoing discussion and the dynamics of the associated interaction. This intermediate course of action avoids asking either substantive-oriented researchers or conversation analysts to expand their domains in ways that are radically disconnected from their traditional interests. To do this, I propose an emphasis on what has been called the *co-construction of meaning* in focus groups.

The Co-Construction of Meaning

The idea of the co-construction of meaning in focus groups comes from the work of Sue Wilkinson (1998a):

> Focus group data offer considerable potential for exploring the co-construction of meaning through

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> an analysis of interactive processes. Sensitively analysed, such data can offer insights into the relational aspects of self, the processes by which meanings and knowledges are constructed through interactions with others, and the ways in which social inequalities are produced and perpetuated through talk.
>
> (p. 123)

In addition, Wilkinson (1998b) discusses five “specific mechanisms through which focus groups elicit participants' own meanings” (p. 334):

1. By enhancing disclosure
2. By providing access to participants' own language and concepts
3. By enabling participants to follow their own agendas
4. By encouraging the production of elaborated accounts
5. By providing an opportunity to observe the co-construction of meaning in action

Once again, however, these processes give an excellent summary of *what* researchers can learn by observing the participants' interaction, but they provide less insight into *how* the participants accomplish these activities. Thus, from a middle-range point of view, this approach reproduces the earlier distinction between the content of the interaction and the conversational processes that produce that content. Closing this gap requires *actively moving back and forth between the interactive dynamics of focus groups and the content of that interaction.* The next two sections each develop an example of connecting conversational dynamics and substantive content. The first part describes “sharing and comparing” as a process that focus group participants typically use in the early stages of their co-construction of meaning, as a way to develop the basic content of their ongoing conversation. The next part looks at “organizing a conceptualizing” as a higher level of the co-construction of meaning, where the participants create and use more abstract versions of the content in their conversations.

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Basic Forms of Interaction in Focus Groups, Part 1: Sharing and Comparing

My earlier works contain several explicit mentions of “sharing and comparing” as a fundamental aspect of interaction in focus groups. For example, at a procedural level, my chapter in the first edition of this volume described how my own moderating style encourages sharing and comparing as a form of interaction among participants (Morgan, 2002). At the level of purposes, the “Introduction to the Focus Group Kit” highlighted the process of sharing and comparing as one of the strengths that focus groups as a specific method added to the general strengths of qualitative methods as a whole (Morgan, 1998, p. 12).

The entry for “focus groups” in the *Sage Dictionary of Social Research Methods* provides a more explicit description of this process (Morgan, 2006):

> When the participants are mutually interested in the discussion, their conversation often takes the form of sharing and comparing thoughts about the topic. That is, they share their experiences and thoughts, while also comparing their own contributions to what others have said. This process of sharing and comparing is especially useful for hearing and understanding a range of responses on a research topic. The best focus groups thus not only provide data on *what* the participants think but also explicit insights into *why* they think the way they do.
>
> (p. 123)

A similar statement in the second edition of *Focus Groups as Qualitative Research* (Morgan, 1997) pays more attention to the interactive exchanges that are central to symbolic interactionism:

> From the researcher's point of view, this process of sharing and comparing provides the rare opportunity to collect direct evidence on how the participants themselves understand their similarities and differences. This actual observation of consensus and diversity is something that can happen quite powerfully through group interaction.
>
> (p. 20)

These statements about sharing and comparing are, however, quite general. In contrast, the current treatment will offer a great deal more detail. To provide some perspective, my emphasis on sharing and comparing

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comes from my observations of interactions in focus groups, followed by examining the transcriptions to check on my interpretation. Thus, my assertions about the importance of sharing and comparing emerge from the same essentially “inductive” process that guides qualitative research in general.

Following a pragmatic orientation, both this section and the next include coverage of both broad purposes and specific procedures. For this section, the first question is this: What are the *purposes* of sharing and comparing that make this process an essential form of interaction in a focus group? In particular, what purposes does it serve for the participants as they create and maintain their discussion? The next question is this: How can researchers design a set of *procedures* that will produce both the levels of and the types of sharing and comparing that are most appropriate for a given project? This is followed by another question: What are the *procedures* that will affect the process of sharing and comparing among the participants? In particular, which procedures should researchers use to encourage the kind of interaction that is most appropriate for a given project? The last questions provide the core content of this section.

Purposes for Sharing and Comparing from the Participants' Perspective

Imagine that the moderator has just asked the first question in a focus group. In addition, assume that it is a well-chosen question, so that each of the participants is interested in the question, has something to say about it, and is interested in hearing what others have to say. Like virtually all conversations, this discussion will involve a process of “turn taking,” where every statement follows the one before it and is in turn followed by the next statement. From the participants' point of view, this need to maintain an orderly conversation means that each of their statements should have an obvious connection to what has already been said and should give particular importance to the remark immediately before their own contribution.

This summary of the mechanics of turning taking in conversations is both intuitively obvious and well established by decades of research. What has received considerably less attention, however, is the way participants link the *content* of what they say with the content of what was just said. This is the most basic element in the co-construction of meaning, and I am proposing sharing and comparing as a basic interactive process that establishes this ongoing connection in focus group interaction. Sharing consists of statements that connect to the previous remark by adding similar content to that remark. Participants thus use sharing to *join* existing elements of the topic. Alternatively, comparing consists of noting a difference between the content of the current statement and the previous remark. Participants thus use comparing to *differentiate* elements of the topic that separate from each other.

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Sharing and comparing are clearly distinct processes, but they serve related purposes for the participants' discussion of the topic. In particular, they each make it possible for participants to *expand* on the content of the ongoing conversation. If this conversation were a continuous piece of speech, sharing and comparing would serve as the "conjunctions" that mark the connection between different segments of the overall content. Like conjunctions as parts of speech, sharing and comparing connect the substantive content of the conversation in focus groups, rather than simply linking the end of one speaker's turn to the beginning of the next. From the participants' point of view, beginning a statement with a form of sharing or comparing signals the relationship between what they are about to say and the content of the previous remark. Thus, a statement that indicates sharing joins similar elements within the topic as a whole, and a statement that indicates comparing points to different aspects of the topic.

For the English language, the analogy of conjunctions to sharing and comparing would match "and" with sharing, while "but" would correspond to comparing. Just as "and" adds to the previous content in a sentence, sharing joins the content in a remark to the previous conversation. Alternatively, just as "but" separates the content in the two halves of a sentence, comparing differentiates the current content from the previous remarks. When participants want to add to and extend the previous remark, they will often begin what they have to say with either the literal word "and" or its equivalent. When they want to differentiate or separate their statement from the previous remark, they will often begin their statement with "but" or its equivalent. Together, sharing and comparing serve as conversation-level "conjunctions" that allow participants to expand on the prior topics in the conversation.

Of course, the English language has a third conjunction, "or," which is a means of offering an alternative. In some instances, "or" signals an alternative that is similar to the content that preceded it, much as "and" does (e.g., "Or another thing that's like that is …"). In other instances, it signals a different alternative, much as "but" does (e.g., "Or a different way of looking at that …"). Thus, "or" as a third English conjunction essentially serves as a way for focus group participants to express one of the other two forms of conjunction, with the specific usage being clear in the context.

Here are some illustrations of "and" and "but" from actual focus groups:

Forms of "And"

And along with that …

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And you've got the same thing when …
That's a great idea, and another piece of it is …

Forms of "But"

But I was thinking of it more as …
One of the big differences is …
In my family, we do almost the exact opposite of that …

Here are two additional, more detailed examples from a study of "Dual Earners in the Sandwiched Generation" (Neal & Hammer, 2006), in which both the partners of a couple were working and the couple had both child care and parent care responsibilities. In this example of sharing, a discussion of issues related to combining work and family duties leads one participant to introduce the topic of the characteristics of a good supervisor, and the next participant adds to the set of experiences that help a supervisor "understand," followed by validation from the first participant.

#1: I've found that where I work, usually the supervisors that are the best are the ones that came up through the ranks, they were workers like you at one time. They seem to understand …

#2: Or if they've "been there." If they have a family then they understand a lot more.

#1: Oh yeah, that makes a difference.

For comparing, the following example involves the topic of sharing your house with an older parent. When the first participant notes that she would be more likely to share her home than her sisters would, the next person differentiates the overall issue of parents living with siblings according to how well it works out for the older parent.

#1: We've thought about it. … [There is an] extra bedroom, and we have teased my mom about it, you know, "If and when you ever need to stay somewhere …" She would probably live with us, but it would not be easy at all. So I don't know. Neither one of my sisters would come through.

#2: But see, then that's where you have got to think, too, "How would I feel if I pushed it on to a sister and then my mom died?" I would feel like I didn't do my part or, I didn't try hard enough or, you know what I mean?

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Sharing and comparing are obviously not the only way that participants can create substantive links between what they are about to say and what has already been said, and the two most obvious alternatives are agreement and disagreement (e.g., Kitzinger, 1994). Conversation analysis, in particular, pays a considerable amount of attention to agreement and disagreement in the context of turn taking (Schegloff, 2007), where they are known as a “preferred” or “dispreferred” response to the prior remark (for a different treatment of this topic, see Hollander & Gordon, 2004, who examine turns as support, challenge, and nonresponse). Although it is tempting to pair sharing with agreement and comparing with disagreement, their function as ways to expand the content of the conversation typically makes them less “charged” than outright agreement or disagreement. Because disagreement is more problematic than agreement, it has received notably more attention (see Myers, 1998, for an application to focus groups). The importance of disagreement makes it worth considering “but” as a conjunction that can indicate a literal form of disagreement. Within the context of sharing and comparing, however, “but” is seldom interpreted as a potential source of conflict; instead, it is far more likely to be treated as a useful contribution to the development of the discussion.

Consider the following example from Macnaghten and Myers (2004), where Myers as a conversation analyst interprets a section of interaction from one of Macnaghten's focus groups on the substantive topic of genetic engineering in animals:

Phil: Can I just say, so in what ways do you think these animals are natural?

M: Well, they won't be natural will they?

Paul: They're not natural, they're man made aren't they.

M: They're engineered.

Iris: But we do that now through interbreeding don't we?

M: But even more so now …

Phil: But that's a point, how is it different from conventional selective breeding? (pp. 74–75)

Myers points out that the last two remarks by participants “both begin [with] ‘but,’ implying a kind of agree/disagree structure.” Yet even though there is a little element of disagreement here, I would argue that it is more useful to interpret this exchange (starting with M's statement, “They're engineered”) as an example of

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comparing, where the idea of interbreeding is differentiated from genetic engineering. Interestingly, this clearly seems to be how Macnaghten, as a moderator, interprets this exchange.

It is also worth noting that agreement and disagreement, in their milder forms, are not necessarily mutually exclusive options for responding to a previous remark. The most common way to convey this kind of mixed message is a kind of “hybrid” conjunction, which often takes the form of “Yes, but …” (e.g., “I agree, but another thing from my perspective is …”). Rather than conveying a mixed message, conjunctions such as “Yes, but …” are more likely to *both* acknowledge the relevance of what was just said and point out different aspects of the topic that would be more relevant in a different context. Using expressions such as “Yes, but …” as a way to signal a *context-dependent form of differentiation* allows participants to describe how shifts in circumstances expand on the topic. Here is a more detailed example of a “Yes, but …” construction from the “Dual Earners in the Sandwiched Generation” study. In this case, the first participant describes her negative experience of living too far from an older parent, while the second participant begins by agreeing about the value of living closer and then shifts over to the alternative advantages of living farther away.

#1: I would say that we need to live in a central location for our jobs and our families. We tried moving out to [a small town], we bought a house out there. It was a disaster. I thought I could handle it and I couldn't. It was too far.

#2: I live close to my parents, too. About a block and half away. And so it is helpful to be close by sometimes. But, on the other hand, being farther away, you aren't called on as often to be there.

Up to this point, my presentation of sharing and comparing has concentrated on the purposes these processes serve in connecting the content in two statements. But they also play an important part in the larger process of co-constructing meaning. More broadly, sharing and comparing are an ongoing process that elicits and shapes the substantive content of the discussion, by establishing connections across the separate contributions from individual participants. Treating sharing and comparing as an ongoing process tells us how participants implicitly define the research topic by what they include within the boundaries of their discussion. From this perspective, participants co-construct their definition of the topic through their interpretation of what is most meaningful with regard to the topic.

Overall, the joint process of sharing and comparing defines the core content of the topic, and this content serves as a continuing context for further development of the discussion. Thus, the co-construction of mean-

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ing requires both a continuing series of connections with the earlier content of the conversation and a substantive expansion of that earlier material. In focus groups, the discussion emerges from participants' efforts to connect and expand on the separate statements in their conversation. But the discussion in focus groups is also a function of the research design that guides the participants, and that is the subject of the next section.

Procedures that Promote Sharing and Comparing: The Researcher's Perspective

This section examines four basic issues that affect the nature of interaction in focus groups. Each of these issues amounts to a decision about the design of a focus group project:

- Who will the participants be?
- How will the group discussion be introduced to the participants?
- What questions will the participants be asked?
- How will the moderator interact with the group during the discussion?

Following the pragmatic emphasis in this chapter, these decisions will be addressed through explicit attention to the overall goals of the research project and the procedures that can address those goals.

The Role of Group Composition in Shaping the Discussion

The first and most important influence on sharing and comparing occurs during the design process, when the research team decides who the participants will be. In terms of how the group composition affects group interaction, the core question is “How will these participants relate to each other in terms of this topic?” The minimum requirement for a good group discussion is that these participants need to be comfortable with talking to the other participants about this topic. Beyond that minimum, sharing and comparing is most likely to occur when the participants are genuinely interested in what each of them has to say about the research topic.

The classic solution to the problem of choosing a group composition that will facilitate interaction is to choose a set of homogeneous participants. The more the participants share similarities before they even start the discussion, the less they will have to explain themselves to each other and the easier it will be to react appropriately to what others say. It is important to note, however, that this kind of homogeneity is *based on similarity*

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with regard to the topic. Despite the repeated emphasis on this point in most textbooks about focus groups, too many researchers still think of homogeneity in terms of background characteristics and demographics; even these factors typically do little to encourage meaningful interaction.

In symbolic interactionist terms, the shared experiences that go with homogeneity make it more straightforward for participants to "take the role of the other." For interactionists, everything that participants say during the discussion is shaped by their sense of how the other participants will react to what they might say. Once the conversation is well under way, direct experience will drive the process of role taking, but the beginning of the group inherently poses more challenges for estimating the likely reactions of the other people around the table. Homogeneity reduces this uncertainty by providing realistic assumptions about how the rest of the group is likely to react.

The Role of the Introduction in Shaping the Discussion

To help participants become engaged in their discussion, the research team has to portray the nature of that discussion, and this matches another key concept from symbolic interactionism: *the definition of the situation.* One basic design dimension that needs to be introduced is the desired degree of structure in the discussion, ranging from less structured groups, where the participants can explore the topic, to more structured groups, where the researcher's predetermined agenda seeks depth and detail about the topic. Once there is a decision about the level of structure that is most appropriate for a given set of research goals, the research team needs to "define the situation" for the participants by describing the nature of the focus group in ways that promote the desired level of structure. From an interactionist perspective, this means helping the participants understand their role as "participants in a group discussion."

In less structured groups, encouraging a process of sharing and comparing involves using the introduction and "ground rules" to create a climate that encourages the expression of a diverse range of opinions. Too often, moderators address issues of diversity in opinions by saying little more than "Remember, there are no right and wrong answers." This is not only a trite expression that participants have heard too many times in too many situations, but it also fails to provide any practical advice on how to handle differences in experiences and viewpoints. In my own instructions, I encourage the expression of diverse viewpoints by extending that all-too-common phrase with something like the following: "For all the questions you'll be discussing, you

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are free to talk about your different experiences and opinions. So, if you think 'that's not how I feel,' then you should speak up."

This definition of the situation helps participants understand our genuine interest in hearing different opinions and experiences, while also indicating when they should be sharing their differences, and providing a model for how to state their differences.

In contrast, defining the situation by a moderator means giving the moderator more control over the discussion. Here is an example of instructions that are designed to encourage a more structured discussion: "I'll be asking the questions I want you to discuss. So, I want to hear lots of different experiences and opinions—as much as you can tell me about my questions."

This definition of the situation allows moderators to pursue their own agenda by simply saying something like, "Remember how I said that I might have to apologize and break into the discussion? So, in the interest of time, I'd like to hear what you have to say about …"

Once the instructions help define the situation for the participants, the next step is to follow through on these expectations *during the group itself.* Ultimately, it is the questions that have the most powerful effect on the definition of the situation for any form of interviewing, and that is the topic for the next section.

The Role of the Interview Questions in Shaping the Discussion

The first question in the focus group can have a crucial impact on the discussion as a whole. It is also important to note that the first question occurs immediately after the instructions—which means that it should follow through on those instructions. For example, when the instructions call for a less structured discussion that asks for different points of view, then the first question should encourage a diverse range of contributions to the discussion. Moving forward from the groundwork laid during the instructions, the first question should serve as a "discussion starter" that matches the goals laid out in the introduction. An example would be something like "Let's start by having you make as long a list as you can of everything that is involved, one way or another, with [topic]" (see Krueger, 1998, for other examples).

There are several basic principles for starter questions that successfully promote interaction in the discussion. A starter question should be

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- Something that is easy for each of the participants to answer
- Something that makes participants want to hear what the other participants have to say
- Something that creates the opportunity to express a diverse range of views

In terms of sharing and comparing, starting with a question that is easy to answer supplies each participant with a reasonably substantial number of potential contributions to the conversation, at the same time that it also creates a comfort level that increases the likelihood of making those contributions. The idea of asking a question where the participants will be interested in what the others have to say corresponds to the earlier advice about selecting a group composition that meets this same standard. Finally, asking questions that create space for multiple points of view means that each participant has a continuing set of options for connecting to the conversation. Taken together, these elements of a successful first question provide the participants with resources that help them discover their similarities and differences through a mutually informative process of sharing and comparing.

One of the key elements of all discussion starter questions is that they need to pay careful attention to participants' needs for generating a discussion. The research team thus needs to balance both their own need for information from the discussion and the participants' need for comfortable interaction. Ultimately, getting high-quality data from the discussion depends on the interaction among the participants. To achieve this goal, the members of the research team have to engage in different forms of role taking: They take the roles of the participants as they are writing the questions. In other words, they need to think as if they were not only participants who are going to respond to these questions as individuals but also ones who can create and maintain an active group discussion around each question.

This first question sets the discussion in motion, but that obviously needs to be followed up by further questions that build on the directions the first question establishes. This means that the sequence of questions in a focus group should flow smoothly with regard to both the substantive topic and the developing group dynamic. Interview guides that produce this level of coherence make all of the other aspects of conducting focus groups much less problematic. In particular, when the situation is well-defined by the instructions and questions, this greatly reduces the potential challenges involved in moderating focus groups.

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The Role of the Moderator in Shaping the Discussion

There is a common, but often mistaken, assumption that the moderator is responsible for creating the conversation in focus groups. What I am claiming, however, is that it is possible to produce the preferred types of group interaction through careful decisions about research design. All of these design decisions help frame the discussion before the moderator takes any action other than delivering the instructions and asking the first question. When these decisions successfully channel the discussion in the desired direction, the moderator's primary job is to assist with the ongoing group dynamics rather than taking responsibility for creating those dynamics.

Consider the moderator's role after a discussion starter question has created a process of sharing and comparing about topics that match the research team's interests. Then the main thing that the moderator needs to do is to listen to the discussion and learn from it. Sooner or later, the moderator will want to probe the group in ways that match the goals for their discussion. For example, in a less structured group with instructions that encourage sharing a wide range of questions, the probes should follow through on that message, with comments such as “Who has something that we haven't heard yet?” If, however, the participants are already meeting the discussion goals on their own, then even this minimal degree of probing may not be necessary.

This final piece of procedural advice reinforces the larger point that appropriate decisions about the group composition, the instructions for the participants, the interview questions, and the role of the moderator have a major influence on the degree of sharing and comparing that occurs in focus groups. Note, however, that this section consistently points out the research team's need to take the participants' perspectives into account. For example, what kind of homogeneity would be most likely to encourage comfortable exchanges about the research topic? Or what kind of discussion starter question would lead to a dynamic where these participants were interested in what the others had to say about the topic? Thus, at every step, researchers need to consider the participant's perspective in order to produce the sharing and comparing that will meet their own research goals.

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Basic Forms of Interaction in Focus Groups, Part 2: Organizing and Conceptualizing

Compared with sharing and comparing, the processes of organizing and conceptualizing typically occur during the later part of focus groups. Once the participants have co-constructed a set of topics that define the topic, they can engage in more interpretive forms of interaction. In particular, the sharing and comparing that happen earlier provide the subject matter that participants organize into broader categories and convert into more abstract concepts. Hence, the co-construction of meaning that results from organizing and conceptualizing is at a “higher level” than the more concrete topics that participants consider in sharing and comparing.

Like the previous section, this one is also divided between the purposes that organizing and conceptualizing can serve for the participants and the procedures that the research team can use to promote these processes. As noted in the introduction, however, the state of knowledge about organizing and conceptualizing is still at a basic level. Thus, the section on the purposes will be more speculative, as opposed to the inductively grounded basis for the description of sharing and comparing. Similarly, the coverage of procedure designs related to organizing and conceptualizing will be more about potential options rather than specific advice. Overall, the goal of this section is to emphasize the importance of organizing and conceptualizing and to encourage more attention to both participants' and researchers' perspectives on these two processes.

Purposes of Organizing and Conceptualizing from the Participants' Perspective

From a symbolic interactionist perspective, organizing and conceptualizing topical material in focus group discussions can be treated as creating and using *social objects.* Callero (1986) summarizes Mead's thinking on this point: “Social objects are said to emerge in the course of interaction and exist only in relation to others” (p. 346). The participants will bring many of these shared social objects with them, based on their shared culture, but they will construct more specific social objects through their immediate conversation. This emphasis on shared social objects is similar to the idea that focus group participants use their interaction to locate a “common ground.” Hyden and Bulow (2003) introduced this term to capture the extent to which participants used prior identities or roles to act as a group rather than as a collection of individuals. Later work (Lehoux, Poland, & Daudelin, 2006; Moen, Antonov, Nilson, & Ring, 2010) followed this tradition by treating common ground as a preexisting characteristic that helps participants act in a coherent, grouplike fashion. In contrast,

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a co-construction of meaning approach concentrates on creating a common ground through the focus group interaction itself. In this case, participants begin with only their shared relationship to the topic, and while this may include similar characteristics, that shared background is neither necessary nor sufficient for achieving a common ground.

The idea that groups can "go beyond" sharing and comparing to "reach the level" of organizing and conceptualizing points to a typical difference between the co-construction of social objects during the earlier and later portions of focus group discussions. After the participants *expand* on the research topic by using sharing and comparing to uncover a broad range of material related to that topic, they can *consolidate* their discussion through the more abstract processes of organizing and conceptualizing. Of course, actual focus groups are quite likely to blend these two processes, but it is still quite reasonable to expect a broad progression from expanding a topic through sharing and comparing toward consolidating that topical material through organizing and conceptualizing.

This two-step process bears a resemblance to a three-part theoretical system from one of my first articles on focus groups, where Margaret Spanish and I examined the interaction in discussions about who has heart attacks and why (Morgan & Spanish, 1985). Our analysis was based on cognitive theories of learning, which pointed to the sequential development of three forms of knowledge. First, the participants generated "episodic knowledge" by telling stories about people they knew who had heart attacks. Second, they compared these stories to produce "categorical knowledge" that almost always used risk factors to discuss who has heart attacks and why. Finally, at least a few groups in this study created "abstract knowledge" about what causes and what prevents heart attacks, through theories that systematically related various risk factors.

The two end points of the previous system correspond to the current description of processes for the co-construction of meaning. On the one hand, episodic knowledge corresponds to the topical content of the conversation that participants develop and expand through sharing and comparing. On the other hand, abstract knowledge matches the products of organizing and conceptualizing. From this perspective, the intermediate level of producing categories can be considered as one component in the more general process of organizing either topical materials into categories or categorical materials into concepts. Thus, in our study on heart attacks, the participants could categorize stories according to the risk factors in each case, or they could categorize risk factors according to how they fit into more abstract conceptual frameworks. Consider this simple example:

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#1: Who did you write about?

#2: A friend of my parents. He had the usual life with a lot of work and a lot of food, a lot of smoking.

#3: How old was this fellow?

#2: Seventy, something like that. But my guess is that lifestyle is very important … (Morgan & Spanish, 1985, p. 409)

In this example, the second speaker uses the emerging system of risk factors to present a “story” that is already more conceptual than the ones that preceded it. Then, when the third speaker inquires about age, the reply emphasizes “lifestyle” as a package of risk factors. This illustrates the common process of organizing concrete categories into more abstract concepts, which can in turn be organized into more complex conceptual frameworks. This architectural metaphor of creating a “conceptual framework” reflects a progressive co-construction of meaning.

Many qualitative researchers will recognize these processes as having much in common with the analysis of qualitative data. In particular, qualitative data analysis often creates categories from topical codes and then converts this category system into a set of themes. These themes organize a number of related ideas into a “conceptual tool” for interpreting the content in a topic area. Interestingly, focus group participants can also label related ideas to produce concepts that are very similar to themes. These selflabeled themes serve an important additional purpose in the ongoing interaction by giving the participants a compact way to refer to a larger package of related material. For example, in one of the heart attack groups, the participants developed the mechanical metaphor of the heart as a pump, leading to a description of one person's stress as so destructive that it was “eating his pump out.”

Perhaps it should not be surprising to find this parallel between qualitative analysis and the interaction among focus group participants, because there is a distinct sense in which they share the same purpose: constructing meaning from the content of the focus group discussion. This also makes perfect sense from a pragmatic point of view, because it points to the fundamental equivalence of research and everyday life. Thus, for pragmatists, the quest for understanding is always a matter of what Dewey (1933) called inquiry, and Dewey also emphasized that the only difference between “lay” and “scientific” inquiry was the degree of care and self-awareness in the latter. Hence, the more solitary construction of meaning that goes into qualitative analysis

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corresponds to the more active co-construction of meaning that occurs during focus groups.

In comparison with researchers, however, participants do not have the liberty to go over the content of the discussion at their leisure. Instead, they have to do their “coding, categorizing, and conceptualizing” during the ongoing flow of the conversation itself. As the conversation proceeds, the meanings that participants construct at earlier points become social objects that they can use in their later discussions. In some cases, these earlier constructions will serve as the basis for further processes of organization and conceptualization. In other cases, the earlier material may be either explicitly examined and found wanting or implicitly ignored as less relevant to the emerging direction of the discussion.

One key point underlying this whole section is the idea that *the ongoing conversation serves as the context for the participants' co-construction of meaning*. Thus, the expansion of the topic through sharing and comparing provides material for consolidation through organizing and conceptualizing. Similarly, some of those “social objects” become themes, and some of those themes provide the basis for conceptual frameworks. All of this assumes a process that moves from lower to higher levels of organization and from more concrete topics to more abstract conceptualizations. Thus, researchers who want to observe phenomena that depend on organizing and conceptualizing will need procedures that can promote this form of interaction.

Procedures that Promote Organizing and Conceptualizing: The Researcher's Perspective

This section will examine three possible techniques for encouraging the process of organizing and conceptualizing. The first involves variations in interviewing techniques, while the second relies on concept mapping, and the third uses repeated interviews. Each of these procedures fits the general pragmatic model of examining possible solutions to a problematic situation—that is, the desire to create research designs that promote organizing and conceptualizing.

Among the various strategies for influencing interaction described in the previous section, the content of the interview questions is most relevant to encouraging conceptualization. In particular, if this set of strategies establishes a comfortable process of sharing and comparing in the earlier parts of the discussion, then the later questions could build on that as a way to move the conversation in more conceptual directions. More specifically, a deeper understanding of both the similarities and the differences among the participants makes it more likely that they will find a common ground for developing shared concepts and themes. Thus, the strat-

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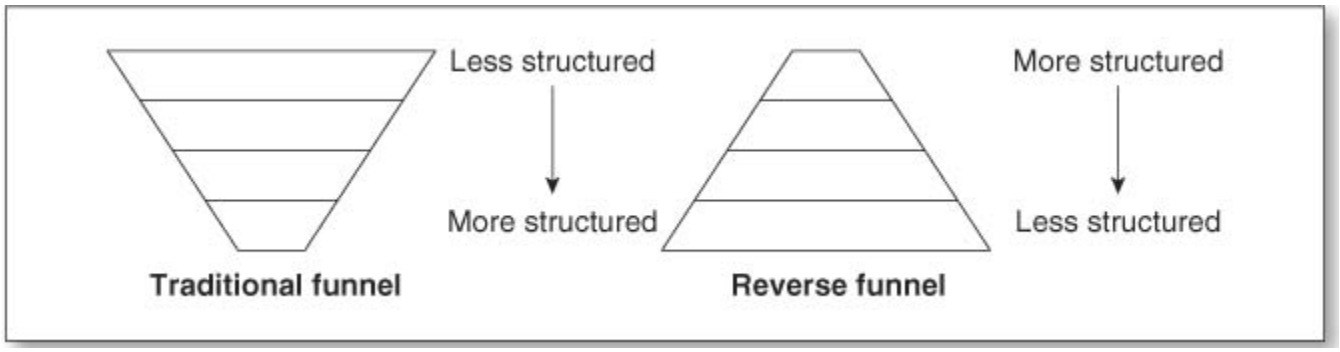
egy is to create appropriate interview questions that can help them create both a common ground and a set of shared concepts and goals.

Interestingly, one of the currently most common forms of organizing interview guides may actually be holding back the kind of interaction that encourages conceptualization. “Funnel-style” interviews, as shown in Figure 10.1, move from broader, more participant-oriented questions to more specific, researcher-oriented questions. This format is especially useful in applied research, where the goal is to learn “what” the participants have to say. If, however, the goal is to learn about the more conceptual aspects of participants' thinking, then the funnel format is less useful, because it moves progressively toward narrower, externally defined questions. In contrast, each of the two other question formats in Figure 10.1 is not only relatively more familiar in current practice but also more likely to lead the discussion in a conceptual direction.

Figure 10.1 Traditional Funnel and Reverse Funnel Formats for Focus Group Interviews



The reverse (or inverted) funnel moves from more specific to more general aspects of the topic, so this is a natural match to encouraging more conceptualization. One widely used implementation of this format begins by asking the participants to think of specific examples that are related to the topic (e.g., “I want you each to tell the rest of the group about someone you know who…”). Following this path, the next question might ask the participants to think about “all the stories you” told and “all the things that mattered with regard to [topic],” and that might be followed by hearing how they would group together the various ideas that are generated, to talk about “how all these things relate to [topic].” This reverse funnel matches the format for the interviews on “who has heart attacks and why” (Morgan & Spanish, 1985). In that case, the broad topic provided the basis for requesting specific stories about people who had heart attacks, followed by using those stories to consider “what makes some people more likely to have heart attacks and other people less likely,” with a final question that asked, “What causes and what prevents heart attacks?” To understand the value of this design in

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this situation, consider what would have happened if we began with the last question. The participants could undoubtedly have discussed that question, but their answers would almost certainly have consisted of highly general statements about various risk factors. That starting point would have created not only little opportunity for sharing and comparing but also equally little incentive to construct personally meaningful conceptual systems.

Beyond the opportunities offered by alternative formats for interview guides, there are a number of other strategies that are oriented toward either smaller or larger aspects of research designs for focus groups. Other techniques that can be used to encourage conceptualization can be found in a book chapter I coauthored with two of my students (Morgan, Fellows, & Guevara, 2008). The most specific strategy from that chapter relies on concept maps as a form of "stimulus material" that requests participants to organize the content from their prior discussion. It should be obvious how this direct request to organize and conceptualize the discussion material can encourage the more abstract thinking that is the goal in this section. This approach typically relies on a two-part question, where the participants begin by either generating a list of concepts or using a predetermined list, with the goal of creating a "map" (actually a structured diagram) that shows the relationships among the concepts. The second part of the question asks the participants to step back from their map and talk about how they chose to create it the way they did—that is, why they organized the concepts into this set of relationships. For example, in the heart attacks study, we could have replaced the last question about "what causes and what prevents" with a request to list and map all the various things that either cause or prevent heart attacks. Follow-up discussions of those maps would have been likely to produce more explicit organizational and conceptual material than we found through our rather generic question.

Another technique from Morgan et al. (2008) involves repeated focus groups, where the first round of groups provides participants who return for further discussions. The easiest way to set up repeated focus groups is to draw the participants for the second round of groups from the "pool" of participants who were in the first round. Because these participants have already engaged in a great deal of topic development during their earlier rounds, they will be in a favorable position for taking that material to the next level. A useful tactic for bringing out that prior topic development is to take advantage of the fact that the "pooled" participants will have been in different groups and therefore to ask them to "compare notes on the different things you discussed in each of your groups." In the Morgan and Spanish study (as reported in Morgan, 1997), we used the first round of participants as a pool for creating a repeated group, to build on their earlier discussions about what causes and what prevents heart attacks.

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A more difficult technique for conducting repeated focus groups is to bring the same set of participants together twice. Although this strategy requires very careful attention to recruitment, it can have very notable benefits with regard to observing interaction. For example, McGregor (2004, 2005) worked with members of environmental organizations. What is especially interesting from the current perspective is that the second round of interviews constructed a degree of consensus that also required a certain amount of “silencing” of alternative views. As I argued at the beginning of this section, outcomes such as consensus seldom evolve in some passive manner; instead, they require active interaction devoted to organizing and conceptualizing, both emphasizing some standpoints and de-emphasizing others.

In considering these procedures for promoting organizing and conceptualizing, it is important to recognize that many focus groups do not need to reach this level of abstraction. Returning to the pragmatic principle that purposes should drive procedures, it is clear that the processes of organizing and conceptualizing are more relevant for some kinds of focus groups than for others. In particular, the classic reason for using a funnel form is to begin by letting the participants expand on the topic, so that the researchers themselves can consolidate the discussion around their own specific interests. Hence, there is nothing inherently valuable in groups that move beyond sharing and comparing to organize their ideas at a higher conceptual level; instead, as always, it depends on the purposes of the research.

Conclusions

Every conversation is about something, and that “something” is the core of focus groups. When we design our data collection, we want to hear what the participants have to say about our research topic. When we analyze the data, we want to understand what the participants have said. At every step, our goal is to listen to and learn from participants' conversations about the topics that interest us.

The first of the four core sections in this chapter dealt with participants' use of sharing and comparing as a type of conversation that develops their understanding of the research topic. Although it is quite literally the interaction in focus groups that produces these conversations, it is participants' interests that move the conversation in one direction or another, as well as favoring one process over another as a way to advance the conversation. From the standpoint of symbolic interaction, this process of sharing and comparing amounts to using sets of social objects that make interaction possible. Whatever meanings the individual participants

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associate with the topic prior to the focus group, sharing and comparing these meanings allow participants to co-construct shared meanings. While individual segments of sharing and comparing are a way to sort out the meanings of specific aspects of the research topic, the overall outcome of this process serves as a way to expand the topic as a whole. This points to the importance of the conversation as an ongoing context, where the earlier parts of the discussion have a continuing influence on what is said later. It is also worth noting that this immediate and local "context" is a major addition to the broader forms of context that surround any given focus group (Hollander, 2004). Overall, the process of sharing and comparing often plays a crucial, early role by developing the topic in ways that sustain the remainder of the discussion.

The section on research procedures for encouraging sharing and comparing showed that there are already a considerable number of techniques available in this area. This does not, however, eliminate the need for innovation. One limitation of the current literature on focus groups is an overreliance on well-accepted procedures, as opposed to experimentation with new and better ways to do focus groups. Hence, there are undoubtedly a large number of procedures related to sharing and comparing that are yet to be discovered, and one goal of this chapter is to raise the awareness of sharing and comparing, to stimulate more research on this fundamental aspect of interaction in focus groups. In particular, if this form of interaction serves as a way of expanding on the research topic, then processes that increase sharing and comparing should produce a richer range of materials. Overall, our procedures for sharing and comparing have been successful, but largely implicit, so more direct attention to these procedures has the potential to make a substantial contribution.

Turning to organizing and conceptualizing, the interactive purposes that these processes serve for participants can be captured with the idea that the conversation is an ongoing context for the coconstruction of meaning. In particular, it helps explain how the earlier development of more concrete material is a necessary precursor for the more abstract work that occurs during organizing and conceptualizing. From the perspective of the overall conversation, the process of sharing and comparing has the advantage of expanding the topic, but this occurs at the "expense" of managing that increasing volume of material. When the participants do continue their discussion through organizing and conceptualizing, it is hardly surprising that this type of interaction is more self-conscious and, thus, more self-evident. Overall, the process of consolidation that arises for organizing and conceptualizing inherently occurs within that context of a developmental trajectory that is unique to each focus group.

In contrast to sharing and comparing, procedures for organizing and conceptualizing constitute an area that explicitly needs more development, and this section of the chapter presented three ideas along this line. The

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first suggestion recommended the use of the inverted funnel as a format for asking questions in a focus group, but we need more ideas about the specific types of questions and lines of questioning that will move participants into a higher level of abstraction. The second suggestion was to use concept mapping as a form of "stimulus material" creating connections between the separate aspects of the research topic, but there are undoubtedly many other forms of stimulus material that accomplish similar goals. The final suggestion was to use repeated focus groups to boost familiarity with the topic, but there are undoubtedly easier ways to do this, such as bringing together participants who are already acquainted with each other — especially when the research topic is a reason for their relationships. Overall, however, it is important not to lose track of the point of these procedures, which is to pursue purposes that engage participants in more complex and abstract aspects of the co-construction of meaning.

As a concluding message, I would interpret this chapter as a relatively rare attempt at systematically addressing interaction in focus groups, in terms of both the value of this interaction for participants and the procedures that researchers can use to encourage the desired forms of interaction. I believe that the best way to move forward with this agenda is to follow the current use of Wilkinson's concept of the co-construction of meaning. The co-construction of meaning is the ultimate source of the data from focus groups, so our own goals and purposes provide a direct justification for investigating how our procedures influence this essential process. Ultimately, we need to think of the co-construction of meaning not only as the way in which participants pursue their discussions but also as the key to pursuing our own research goals.

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